REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 05



Product / Project Translator

THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Find out what they need to decide. Give them a useful answer without promising work you cannot yet describe.

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For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

START WITH A REAL SITUATION. DECIDE WHAT HAPPENS NEXT.

WORKING EDITION / REBEL-LEADER.COM

“Can you just give me the final requirements?”

You are still finding out what customers need. Someone needs a feature list, a date, or a budget. Both of you need an answer you can use. Start by asking what they need the answer for.

Find the decision behind the question

Finance may need to reserve money. Sales may need to tell a customer when to expect something. Another team may need to plan its work. Ask rather than guessing.

Say what you can answer now

If the work is understood and the team can give a reliable date, use it. If an important question is still open, explain exactly what it is.

Offer a useful next step

Perhaps you can agree to test two booking designs with customers in the next two weeks, then bring a build estimate to Finance. Name the work, the limit, and what they will be able to decide afterward.

Write a reply you would actually say

The Lab helps you check the request, prepare a commitment, and write the response. You do not need to teach someone product-management vocabulary before helping them plan.

> Try: “What do you need the feature list for? Which decision are you trying to make, and when do you need to make it?”

You can be frustrated and still be curious.

A request for final details can feel like somebody has misunderstood your job. They may simply be trying to do theirs. Find out what they need before correcting them.

What actually happened?

Write down what was said or done. Then notice what you have added. “They asked for Friday” and “They do not care about the team” are different statements. You can check the first. You need to ask about the second.

Why do you care?

Who would be better off if this worked? A customer could stop chasing an answer. Your team could finish the work it promised. Start there. Give the other person a chance to tell you what matters to them too.

What would better look like?

Imagine the next few weeks going well. What would people be doing differently? Describe that in ordinary words, then ask the other person what they would add or change.

Keep these notes to yourself

Private notes in the Lab stay only in the open tab. They disappear when you refresh or leave and never appear in your exported documents. You can also think through these questions without typing.

> An opening you can adapt: “I want us to find a way through this. Can we look at what is happening and work out what to do next?”

Ask what they will use the answer for.

Your first interpretation might be wrong. Give the person a chance to explain.

“We need final requirements”

“Which decision depends on that list? Do you need to reserve money, agree a contract, or get another team ready?” Find out which details need to be settled now.

“We need a firm date”

“Who is waiting for it, and what have they been told?” Ask the team for its current delivery estimate and what could change it.

“We need the full roadmap”

“How far ahead do you need to plan, and what will you use it for?” Explain which work is agreed, which is only a possibility, and when you will know more.

Record what they actually confirm

If you have not asked yet, write the question you will ask. Do not turn your guess about their motives into a fact in the reply.

> You are looking for an answer that helps them make their decision. Check that you understand it before writing the response.

What can we promise at this point?

Uncertainty does not have to leave the other person empty-handed. Be specific about what you can do and what they will learn from it.

Start with what you know

For example, customers currently phone to book repairs. There are two possible online designs. Neither has been tried with customers.

Name the question that matters

Can customers complete a booking using either design? How much work would the better one take to build? Say how you will find out.

Propose the work and its limits

Ask to spend up to $5,000 over two weeks to try both designs with five customers and get an Engineering estimate. Name who does each part. Those are fictional example amounts, not recommended defaults.

Explain what comes afterward

Bring the findings and estimate to Finance. Ask whether to fund the build, change the idea, or stop. Do not promise a finished service when you are only promising a customer test.

> A useful commitment says what you will do, who will do it, how much time or money you will use, and when the other person will hear back.

Say it as you would in the meeting.

Start with what they need. Then explain what you can offer and ask for the decision you need.

Show that you heard them

“You need a spending limit by Thursday.” Use the need they confirmed, rather than an explanation you invented.

Make a concrete offer

“Could we set aside up to $5,000 for two weeks to try both booking designs with five customers and check the build work with Engineering?”

Explain what they will get back

“We will bring you the results, an estimate, and a recommendation before asking you to pay for the full build.”

Ask for a response

“Would that give you enough to make Thursday's decision?” Let them tell you if the offer does not meet their need. Revise it together.

> Read the message aloud. If you would not say a phrase in conversation, find the words you would use.

Keep working on the actual question.

Sometimes the first offer will not be enough. Ask what is missing.

“Just give me the date”

If the team has a reliable estimate for the agreed work, share it with its assumptions. Otherwise say what needs checking and when you can return with an estimate. Use Deadline Reset if a date has already been promised.

“We cannot approve an open-ended budget”

Agree a maximum spend and a stopping point. Explain what that money buys and what will still be unknown. The person paying can change or decline the proposal.

“We need to tell the customer something”

Work with the person responsible for that customer. State what is available, what is still being checked, and when the next update will come. Check any existing contractual promise.

“Why does the plan keep changing?”

Explain what you learned and how it changed the choice. If poor planning or communication also played a part, say so. Learning does not excuse keeping people in the dark.

> Try: “I want to give you something you can plan around. Which part of this still leaves you unable to make the decision?”

Finance needs a budget by Thursday.

Fictional example: the finance director asks for the final feature list for an online repair-booking service. Customers have not tried either proposed design yet.

The product manager asks why

Finance needs a spending limit by Thursday. They do not need every screen agreed. The product manager checks that understanding before proposing a smaller first spend.

The proposed commitment

Propose spending up to $5,000 over two weeks to let five customers try both designs and ask Engineering what each would take to build. The product manager arranges the customer sessions; the engineering lead estimates the build work.

The reply

You need a budget by Thursday. Could we approve up to $5,000 for two weeks of customer testing first? Then we can show you which design works and what it would take to build before you commit to the full cost.

What happens next

In this example, Finance approves the limited spend on Thursday. The product manager books the customer sessions and the review two weeks later. Funding for the full build is still undecided. The Lab example starts before approval.

> Finance can plan the immediate spend. The team knows what to test. Nobody has pretended that the final design or full delivery date is already known.

Bring the sentence you heard.

You can prepare the reply before the conversation and update it after you have checked what the other person needs.

The request

Record their words, who asked, and what they need to decide. The starter buttons can help you begin; edit the wording to match your situation.

What they need

Choose the reason they need an answer, record what they confirmed, and name anything you still need to check. Build What They Need if you want to review your understanding.

What we can promise

Write what you know, what is still uncertain, and what you can offer now. Include the time, money, and other limits. Build Proposed Commitment.

Your reply

Write the short spoken version if useful, then the message. Name the decision you need and when. Build Your Reply as a proposal. Return after the conversation to record the answer and the next action.

> Load Examples shows the fictional booking-service case. Use your own facts before sharing a document.

Did anything actually change?

A completed form can look satisfying. The useful part is what people do with it.

Follow up

Bring the promised findings on the agreed date. Ask whether they helped the person make the decision. If you misunderstood the need or promised something too vague, revise the offer and check it with them.

Try saying it out loud

Read your proposed message to someone you trust. Ask where they got lost or what sounded strange. Could you say this to the person in a real meeting? Change anything you would have to translate as you spoke.

Keep the record

Copy, download, or print anything you need to keep. Shared answers save in this browser on this device; they do not follow you to another device. Private notes are not saved. Export before clearing a draft or browser data.

Check what happened

Was the decision understood? Did someone act? Did the change help the people it was meant to help? If nobody responded, find out who can decide and agree when to ask again. Silence does not mean yes.

> You do not have to fix the whole organization in one conversation. Leave knowing what happens next, who will do it, and when you will check back.